

Chicago Tribune



\$5.75 | SUNDAY, JUNE 28, 2026 | CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

AMERICA 250

Reflections on citizenship

New US citizens in Chicagoland share the joys and struggles of their journeys as nation hits landmark anniversary

By Angie Leventis Lourgos
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

For much of his life, the pastor considered his immigration status akin to a legal purgatory.

At the age of 6, his undocumented mother and father brought him from his birthplace of Guadalajara to the Southeast Side of Chicago in search of a better life for their family in the United States.

The Rev. Edgar Torres has few memories of growing up in Mexico but vivid ones of singing “The

Star-Spangled Banner” alongside his classmates as a little boy.

“At a young age, you don’t know if you’re undocumented or documented. You’re just a child,” he recalled. “I thought I was a proud American because I didn’t even know I was a citizen of Mexico. Because I always found the U.S. to be my country.”

Despite this strong sense of belonging and patriotism, he was essentially living on the margins, first without legal authorization as a child and later as a Deferred Action

for Childhood Arrivals recipient for roughly a decade during adulthood.

Yet a quarter century after his immigration, Torres was finally able to become a citizen and formally take the oath of allegiance to the nation he had long known and loved during his naturalization ceremony in October at the Dirksen U.S. Courthouse in Chicago.

Surrounded by his wife, baby daughter, parents — who by then held green cards — and dozens of

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The Rev. Edgar Torres, who was born in Mexico and became a U.S. citizen, greets people after a service on June 14 at New Community Covenant Church in Chicago’s Logan Square neighborhood. BRIAN CASSELLA/TRIBUNE



‘THEY DON’T WANT TO GIVE US CLEAN AIR’

Gary residents say US Steel is jeopardizing jobs, health. The company says modern furnaces are too costly

Above: Natalie Ammons holds a nebulizer device shaped like a fish that her great-grandchildren, including Alivia, 4, Adonis, 5, and Eli, 4, sometimes use to help their breathing, after they played on May 26 outside her home near the U.S. Steel Gary Works plant in Gary.

BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

By John Lippert and Maya Wilkins
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

To escape a surge in Chicago’s gang violence, Natalie Ammons and her family moved in 1979 to a home just a few hundred yards from one of the world’s biggest steel mills.

On some nights, when the Gary mill pounded its red-hot steel slabs into thin sheets, she’d see flames shoot up through the smokestacks. She’d go to bed to the sound of rumblings from the mill and the smell of rotten eggs. In the morning, she’d find greasy, black particles scattered on her lawn, sidewalk and car.

Ammons, 71, said she never thought much about air pollution, not even as her coughing and chest colds got worse and worse. She was too busy catching the train to Chicago to run document retrieval for a big law firm.

What really scared her — and transformed her into a clean-air activist — was the first time she saw the breathing machines that her three great-grandchildren, Adonis, Alivia and Eli, use to recover from asthma attacks that doctors say are more common among children in Gary than nearby towns.

See GARY on Page A14

Chicago’s 911 mental health team flounders

Group’s dispatch volume down despite Johnson’s campaign promises

By Alice Yin
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Throughout his 2023 mayoral campaign, Brandon Johnson championed a progressive vision of sending teams of mental health clinicians instead of police officers to help people suffering from psychiatric emergencies.

But since he took office and started phasing cops out of the city’s Crisis Assistance Response and Engagement program, those teams of mental health workers have struggled to respond to 911 calls. CARE’s dispatch volume plummeted almost 70% during his second year, according to data obtained via a public records request, and plunged again last year after the Chicago Police Department took back its devices that provide real-time updates on radio and dispatch communications.

Those in-vehicle machines, known as portable device terminals, were a critical tool for teams of mental health workers to learn about psychiatric emergencies they could help defuse. Proponents of CARE have long argued that police are not well-suited for managing those scenes, but without access to those live devices, scores of 911 calls involving Chicagoans who may need mental health assistance are once again only getting police and Fire Department responses.

The Johnson administration has still not managed to get those terminals back to the CARE teams, nor will it say whether it ever intends to. Instead, the mayor’s team touted a still-in-progress overhaul of the emergency dispatch system that would allow CARE to bypass police and fire channels.

The program’s struggles since

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NATION & WORLD

US says it hit targets in Iran

The U.S. military said it struck multiple targets in Iran on President Donald Trump’s direction, continuing attacks that have shaken an uneasy ceasefire. **Page B5**

SPORTS

Summer of love ... and soccer

Paul Sullivan’s 12 takeaways from the summer, from a Cubs history lesson to the World Cup tourists’ love for U.S. hospitality to a gift for the pope and more.

ARTS & ENTERTAINMENT

Chiseling out ‘Iceboy!’

The Goodman Theatre’s big summer musical, the finale to its centennial season, is being put together bit by bit, piece by piece, using trial and error.

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